52 HOURS TO A WINNING INTERVIEW

Real cases, strong answers and the words that decide



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REAL CASES, REAL ANSWERS,
AND WHY THEY WORK

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The people described in this book are composites. Their names are invented. Employers are named as illustrations of what different sectors assess; no organization named has endorsed this book or disclosed its interview questions.

Research findings are cited in plain language, with full sources listed at the end of the book.

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First edition

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This is not a book of rules.

It is a book of fifty-two Brazilians.

Each case is short. It describes a real kind of situation, what the candidate actually did, and — this is the part most interview books leave out — **why it worked**. Not why it sounds nice. Why it produced a result.

You can read this book in any order. Give each case about an hour — read it, then do the one thing at the end — and you have fifty-two hours of preparation, which is where the number comes from. Or read the whole thing in an afternoon before an interview. Both work.

The book has six parts; the first four contain the cases:

Part One — What You Bring to the Table. Twelve cases about finding out what you actually have to offer, which is almost always more than you think.

Part Two — Presence. Thirteen cases about how you speak, how you sit, how you sound, and how much of that can be prepared in advance.

Part Three — Strong Answers. Nineteen cases built around real interview questions. Each one gives you a strong answer and then takes it apart to show you the machinery.

Part Four — The Whole Interview. Eight cases about the things that happen around the answers.

Part Five — The Portuguese Section. Not cases. Four reference chapters written for one specific reader: the words that change your meaning, the sounds that make a listener work harder, what to remove from and include in

your résumé, and what each B.C. sector is actually testing. If you read nothing else in this book, read the first two.

Part Six — The Words You Will Need. Also not cases. The verbs, sentences and workplace vocabulary that do the actual work in a Canadian interview, most of them lifted from the strong answers in Part Three — ending with the phone screen, the one interview made of nothing but words. Use it as a phrasebook.

Every case ends with **Your Turn** — one thing to do. Not five things. One.

◆

A NOTE ON THE EVIDENCE

Where a case rests on published research, the source appears at the end of it.

Where it rests on ordinary professional craft, no source appears, because inventing one would be dishonest.

A few popular pieces of interview advice have been deliberately left out of this book because the evidence behind them collapsed when other researchers tried to reproduce it. If you have been told that standing in a "power pose" for two minutes before an interview changes your hormones, or that words account for only seven percent of communication, you have been told things that do not hold up. The second one is particularly damaging if English is not your first language, because it tells you the words matter least. They do not. They matter most.

What follows is what survives.

◆

A NOTE ON THE PEOPLE

The people in these cases are composites. They are built from the ordinary situations that come up again and again — a nurse whose credentials are still under assessment, a night-shift supervisor rebuilding a career in logistics, a parent returning to work after two years at home.

Their names are invented. Their problems are not.

The employers named are real, and are named because they are the kinds of organizations people in British Columbia actually apply to. They are illustrations, not predictions. Nobody at Vancouver Coastal Health or BC Hydro has told me what they ask. The point of naming them is that a health authority and a construction firm are testing different things, and you should walk in knowing which.

PART ONE

WHAT YOU BRING TO THE TABLE

Most people preparing for an interview start with the questions.

That is the wrong end.

Start with the inventory — what you have done, what you can prove, what you know that other candidates do not. The questions are only the doors through which that material walks into the room.

Twelve cases about building the material.

CASE 1

The Inventory Before the Search

Marcela, 38 — arrived in Surrey from Porto Alegre fourteen months ago, applying to the BC Public Service

Marcela had been applying for administrative positions for five months. Her résumé listed three jobs and the dates she held them. When she was invited to interviews, she found she could describe her duties but could not say much about her results.

Before her sixth application, she stopped applying and spent two evenings making a list. Not a résumé. A list.

She wrote down every project she had been part of, every problem she had personally solved, every process she had changed, every person she had trained, every complaint she had handled. She wrote them in Portuguese first, because it was faster, and translated afterwards.

The list ran to forty-one items. Her résumé had shown eleven lines.

Why it worked

A résumé records positions. An inventory records evidence. When an interviewer asks a behavioural question, they are asking you to retrieve one specific item from a large collection — and you cannot retrieve from a collection you have never assembled.

Marcela did not memorize answers. She built the raw material that answers are made from. When she was later asked about a time she had improved something, she did not search her memory under pressure. She chose.

Your turn

Set a timer for thirty minutes. Write every work situation you can remember in which something changed because you were there. Do not filter. Do not write in English if English is slower.

CASE 2

The Job She Was Embarrassed About

Ana, 41 — a nurse in Brazil, working in a warehouse in Delta, applying to Vancouver Coastal Health

Ana had eleven years of nursing experience and a foreign credential still under assessment. For nineteen months she had worked night shifts in a distribution

warehouse. When she interviewed for a health care assistant role, she planned not to mention the warehouse at all. It embarrassed her.

Her interviewer asked what she had been doing since arriving in Canada.

Ana told the truth, and then she kept going. She described how the night shift ran, how she had noticed that one loading process was producing repeated errors on the same product line, how she had raised it with a supervisor, and how the checking step she suggested was still in use.

She got the job.

Why it worked

Two things happened. The first is that hiding nineteen months creates a hole, and interviewers notice holes. The second is more important: employers weight Canadian work experience heavily, and the warehouse was Canadian work experience. It was also full of exactly the material the interview was asking for — noticing a problem, raising it, changing something.

The job Ana was ashamed of was not the obstacle. It was the evidence.

Statistics Canada census data shows immigrants who studied outside Canada are roughly twice as likely to be working below their qualifications as immigrants who studied in Canada. This is common. It is not a personal failure.

Your turn

Take the job you have been leaving out. Write down three things that happened in it that show how you work.

CASE 3

Making a Foreign Employer Legible

Rafael, 45 — twelve years at a logistics company in Campinas, applying to a CN freight terminal in Surrey

Rafael's employer was a substantial company with 800 staff and national contracts. In Vancouver, nobody had heard of it. Interviewers heard an unfamiliar name and moved on, and Rafael could feel the information landing as nothing.

He built one sentence and used it every time.

"I worked for one of the larger distribution companies in the Campinas region — about eight hundred employees, roughly the size of a mid-sized Canadian logistics firm. I ran the night operation for four of those years."

Fifteen seconds. Then he continued with whatever the question had actually been.

Why it worked

An interviewer cannot evaluate what they cannot picture. When they hear an unknown employer, they do not think "that sounds impressive"; they think nothing at all, and your twelve years quietly become invisible.

Rafael did the translation work himself instead of leaving it to a stranger. He gave a size, a rank and a Canadian comparison — three handles the interviewer could grip.

Your turn

Write one sentence that makes your last employer understandable to somebody who has never heard of it. Include a number. Practise it until it takes fifteen seconds.

CASE 4

The Number He Did Not Know He Had

Bruno, 29 — retail supervisor, applying to London Drugs in Burnaby

Bruno was asked about a time he had improved something. He described reorganizing the stockroom at his previous shop. The answer was fine and entirely forgettable, because it contained no scale. The interviewer had no way to know whether this was a cupboard or a warehouse.

Afterwards he worked out what he actually knew. The shop had six staff. Before the change, finding stock for a customer took what felt like three or four minutes; afterwards it was under a minute. He had no formal measurement. But he had numbers.

At the next interview he was tempted to go further. A precise figure would sound stronger, and he considered saying he had cut retrieval time by sixty-five percent.

He did not. He said this instead:

> *"It was a six-person shop. Finding stock for a customer went from around three or four minutes to under one, and that happened many times a day. I don't have an exact measurement — I noticed because customers stopped waiting at the counter."*

Why it worked

Numbers are not there to impress. They are there so the listener can picture the situation. "I reorganized the stockroom" could describe almost anything. "Six staff, three minutes down to one, many times a day" can only describe one thing.

Bruno had no data. He had ordinary knowledge of his own workplace, which is what most people have and most people discard.

The refusal to invent a percentage is the other half. Interviewers ask follow-up questions, and an invented statistic has to be defended — how was it measured, over what period, against what. Saying "I don't have an exact measurement" costs nothing and buys credibility for every other number in the interview. In regulated sectors it signals something employers care about a great deal: that you know the difference between what you measured and what you observed.

Your turn

Take one story from your inventory. Find three numbers in it — people, minutes, money, frequency. Then mark each one *measured* or *estimated*, and say which is which when you practise.

CASE 5

What His Last Manager Would Say

Diego, 33 — construction, applying to Ledcor in Langley

Diego was asked how his previous manager would describe him. He said he was hardworking and reliable, which is what almost everyone says, and the interviewer moved on without writing anything down.

He prepared differently for the next one. He thought about what his manager had actually said to him, in real conversations, over four years — and remembered being handed the difficult clients. Repeatedly. Not the biggest jobs. The awkward ones.

"He'd say I was the person he sent to the difficult clients. I don't think he thought I was the fastest, but if a customer was angry, I was the one who went."

Why it worked

The first answer was a claim about himself. The second was a report of somebody else's behaviour — and behaviour is evidence in a way that adjectives are not. It also included a limitation, which made the rest believable.

Interviewers hear "hardworking and reliable" dozens of times a week. They have no way to test it and they stop listening. Diego gave them something that could only have come from a real job.

Your turn

Do not ask yourself what your qualities are. Ask what your manager kept giving you to do, and why they chose you for it.

CASE 6

The Volunteer Work That Counted

Larissa, 26 — arrived on a working holiday permit, applying for a coordinator role at a settlement non-profit

Larissa had eight months of Canadian work, all of it in cafés. She also spent Saturday mornings helping run a community language exchange in East

Vancouver — scheduling volunteers, booking the room, managing a WhatsApp group of about seventy people.

She had left it off her résumé, because it was not paid.

An interviewer asked about coordinating people. Larissa mentioned the language exchange almost as an afterthought, and then found she had four minutes of concrete material: no-show rates, a scheduling change she made, what happened when two volunteers stopped speaking to each other.

Why it worked

Behavioural interview questions ask what you did, not who paid you. Unpaid work produces exactly the same evidence — deadlines, conflicts, coordination, judgment — and it frequently produces better evidence than a junior paid role, because volunteers cannot be ordered around and have to be persuaded.

Larissa's café work showed she could hold a job. The language exchange showed she could run something.

Your turn

List anything you organize or have organized outside paid work. A church group, a football team, a family move, a community page. Find the coordination problem in it.

CASE 7

Reading the Posting as a Scoring Sheet

Camila, 36 — applying to Fraser Health

Camila noticed that the job posting listed six things under "Qualifications" and four under "Competencies", and that the language was oddly formal and repetitive.

She treated the list as what it was: a set of headings somebody would be scoring her against.

She printed it, put a line under each competency, and wrote beside each one the story she would use. Two competencies had no story. She spent her preparation time on those two rather than rehearsing the ones she was already comfortable with.

Why it worked

Large public employers — health authorities, government, universities, Crown corporations — frequently build their interview questions directly from the posted competencies, and score answers against a written guide. The posting is not marketing copy. It is a syllabus.

Camila did the thing most candidates never do: she prepared for the questions she was weakest on instead of the ones that made her feel prepared.

Structured interviews of this kind are the most accurate hiring method in the research literature — among the most accurate methods available. They also reward preparation more than any other format. Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2022.

Your turn

Print the posting. One line per requirement. Write your story beside each. Find the empty lines. That is your homework.

CASE 8

The Gap She Stopped Apologizing For

Patrícia, 44 — two years out of the workforce after arriving with two children, applying to WorkSafeBC

Patrícia had rehearsed an apology. She had a paragraph explaining the two-year gap, and it was defensive, and it made the gap sound worse than it was.

She replaced it with two sentences.

"I arrived in 2023 and spent the first two years getting my family settled and completing my credential assessment. I started looking for work in March."

Then she stopped talking. She did not explain further, and no interviewer ever asked her to.

Why it worked

Length signals discomfort. A four-sentence explanation of a two-year gap tells the interviewer the gap is a problem; two flat sentences tell them it is a fact.

Patrícia also gave the gap a content — settling a family, completing an assessment — rather than leaving it empty. An accounted-for gap is not a gap. It is a period.

Your turn

Write your gap explanation. Then cut it to two sentences and practise stopping.

CASE 9

What He Had That They Did Not

Thiago, 31 — logistics coordinator, applying to a Port of Vancouver freight forwarder with Latin American suppliers

Thiago had spent months thinking about what he lacked. Canadian experience. Local references. Native fluency.

Then he read the company's site properly and found they had three suppliers in Brazil and one in Chile.

In the interview he said something no other candidate could have said:

"I've worked with suppliers in São Paulo and I know how the shipping documentation works on that side. I also know how long things actually take there, as opposed to what the schedule says."

Why it worked

Newcomers spend enormous energy on their deficits and almost none on their advantages, and the advantages are frequently the more relevant of the two. Language, market knowledge, supplier relationships, understanding a customer base, having done the same job under harder conditions with fewer resources — these are assets, and nobody will identify them for you.

Thiago stopped competing on the ground where he was weakest.

Your turn

Find one thing you know that a Canadian-raised candidate for this job almost certainly does not. Write the sentence that says it.

CASE 10

The Repository He Could Open in the Interview

Rodrigo, 33 — six years as a backend developer in Florianópolis, eleven months in Vancouver, applying to a backend role at Microsoft's Vancouver office

Rodrigo's résumé worked. He passed recruiter screens easily — six years, real systems, a stack that matched the posting.

He kept dying in the technical conversation, and not because he could not code.

Everything he had built in six years sat behind a corporate firewall. He could describe it, and describing it sounded like every other candidate describing work nobody could see. His GitHub profile held a forked tutorial from 2021 and nothing else.

In one interview he was asked what he had built with AI. He said he used Copilot daily and had done a lot with ChatGPT.

The interviewer nodded and wrote nothing down.

Over the next seven weeks he built two things and finished one. A settlement non-profit in East Vancouver had roughly four hundred pages of program rules that their front-desk staff could not search. He built them an assistant that answered questions about it.

The first version was worse than useless. Asked about an eligibility deadline, it produced a confident, fluent, wrong date.

So he rebuilt it so that it could not answer without showing the paragraph it took the answer from, and would say it did not know rather than guess. Then

he did the part almost nobody does: he wrote down sixty questions the thing ought to get right, ran them, and recorded the score.

It scored fifty-two.

He wrote a README explaining what it does, why he chose that model, what it gets wrong, and what he would do next. He deployed it. He kept the eight failures in the repository instead of deleting them.

At his next interview he was asked the same question.

"I built a documentation assistant for a settlement non-profit here. Their staff had four hundred pages of program rules and could not find anything in them. It answers with the paragraph it took the answer from, so a person can check it, and it refuses rather than guessing. It's live — about thirty staff use it. I have a sixty-question test set. It gets fifty-two right, and I can show you the eight it doesn't."

The interviewer opened the repository during the call. Every follow-up question for the next twenty minutes came out of it.

Why it worked

The sentence that did the work was the last one. *I can show you the eight it doesn't.*

Rodrigo's first answer — I use Copilot, I've done a lot with ChatGPT — was a claim about himself, and claims about yourself are the weakest material in an interview. It is the same answer Diego gave when he called himself hardworking and reliable, and it was received the same way. The second answer was an artifact somebody else was using, with a measured result and a documented failure attached to it.

Experienced engineers are in an unusual bind here: the better your career, the less of it you are allowed to show. Six years of serious work behind an NDA is worth less in a room than one small thing an interviewer can open. That is not fair, and it is the situation.

The evaluation set is the part to copy. Employers have largely stopped separating people who use AI from people who do not, because that distinction no longer tells them anything. They are separating people who use AI from people who can build something reliable around it — which means verification, measurement, and knowing what the system does when it is wrong. Rodrigo's sixty questions were not an impressive piece of engineering. They were a claim he could substantiate, which is the standard Bruno met when he refused to invent a percentage.

The signal is now measurable at the application stage. In an experiment with 1,725 recruiters in the United Kingdom, the United States and Germany, candidates whose résumés showed AI skills were roughly eight to fifteen percentage points more likely to be invited to interview, software-engineering roles included. Two findings in it matter especially to readers of this book: the effect was largest for candidates who were older or had less formal education, and self-declared skills performed nearly as well as formal certificates. Stephany, Teutloff and Leone, working paper, 2026.

It is also moving outside technology quickly. In September 2026 UBS made demonstrated AI proficiency a requirement for junior banking hires and interns joining in 2027, with interview questions about how candidates actually use the tools. Financial Times, September 2026.

Which is why this case is not only for developers. Rodrigo's advantage was not that he could code — most of his competitors could code. It was that he arrived with something an interviewer could open, and with an honest

account of where it fails. A nurse, a bookkeeper, a coordinator can meet that standard without writing a line of software. The artifact changes by profession. The standard does not.

Your turn

Build the smallest thing somebody other than you would actually use — then build the second thing, which is the one candidates skip: a list of twenty questions it should get right, the record of how many it got right, and a note about the ones it did not.

If you do not write software, the second thing is still the assignment. Find the version of your work that another person could open, use or check, and be the one who says where it fails before they ask.

CASE 11

Knowing His Number Before They Asked

Rafael, continued

Rafael was asked his salary expectations twelve minutes into an interview. He had not prepared, so he named a figure well below what the role paid, and he could see the interviewer's face change.

He prepared afterwards. He checked the posted range where one existed, looked at three comparable postings, spoke to two people in the sector, and settled on a range with a floor he would not go below.

At his next interview he said:

"Based on what I've seen for similar roles in the Lower Mainland, I'd be looking at somewhere between eighty-eight and ninety-eight thousand, depending on the full scope. Does that fit your range?"

Why it worked

The first number spoken tends to anchor everything after it. A candidate who names a low figure has not been modest; they have set a ceiling.

Rafael's version does three things: it shows research, it gives a range rather than a point, and it hands the question back. British Columbia now requires pay ranges in publicly advertised postings and does not allow employers to ask what you were paid before, which means the research is often already done for you.

Your turn

Find your floor before your next interview. Write it down. Do not go into a room without it.

CASE 12

The Question Behind the Job

Larissa, continued

Larissa prepared by memorizing facts about the organization — founding year, number of locations, the mission statement on the front page.

None of it was ever asked.

What she was asked was why she wanted the job. Her fact-based answer was flat, because facts are not reasons.

She changed her preparation. Instead of learning about the organization, she worked out what problem the role existed to solve. The posting mentioned a new location opening and a backlog of scheduling requests. So the role existed because something was growing faster than the current system could handle.

"It looks like you're growing and the scheduling is straining. That's the kind of problem I like — I did something similar with a volunteer roster that had outgrown a spreadsheet."

Why it worked

Every job exists because someone has a problem. Candidates who research the organization can recite it. Candidates who identify the problem can offer to solve it, which is a different conversation and a much shorter route to being wanted.

Your turn

Read the posting again and answer one question: what is going wrong, or growing, that made them write this?

PART TWO

PRESENCE

There is a great deal of nonsense written about body language in interviews.

Some of it has been tested and failed. Standing in a "power pose" before an interview does not change your hormones. Words do not account for only seven percent of communication — that figure comes from a study about contradictory emotional signals and was never a claim about ordinary speech.

What is true is quieter and more useful. How fast you speak affects whether you are believed. The first two minutes affect the score. Rehearsal improves performance, and it improves the accuracy of the interview at the same time. Nerves are reduced more effectively by structure than by confidence.

Thirteen cases about the part of the interview that is not the content.

CASE 13

Practising Out Loud

Marcela, continued

Marcela prepared by reading her notes. She knew her stories well, could recall every detail, and felt ready.

In the interview, the words would not assemble. She knew what had happened; she could not narrate it. She finished each answer knowing she had told it badly.

She changed one thing. She began practising out loud, standing up, speaking to an empty room. The first attempt at each story was clumsy. The third was fluent.

Why it worked

Knowing a story and telling a story are different skills, and only one of them can be practised silently. Reading your notes rehearses recognition. Speaking rehearses production — finding the words, ordering the clauses, getting to the end of a sentence you started.

This gap is wider in a second language, because the production step costs more. Silent preparation hides the cost entirely and then presents you with the bill in the room.

Your turn

Pick one story. Tell it out loud three times. Notice that the third is better than the first, then apply that everywhere.

CASE 14

The Recording

Diego, continued

Diego recorded himself on his phone answering three questions, then watched it back, which he described afterwards as unpleasant.

He noticed things nobody had told him. He began three answers with "So, basically." He looked at the ceiling while thinking. He ran two sentences together with "and" until the listener could not tell where one idea ended.

None of these were serious. All were fixable, and none would have been visible from the inside.

Why it worked

You cannot correct what you cannot observe, and you cannot observe yourself while speaking. Practice works best when something tells you what to change — and a phone is a feedback machine you already own.

The discomfort is the point. It is easier to watch yourself now than to wonder afterwards.

Interview preparation that combines instruction, practice and feedback has been shown to improve performance in structured interviews. Tross and Maurer, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2008.

Your turn

Record one answer. Watch it once. Write down one habit. Do not try to fix everything.

CASE 15

Slower on Purpose

Ana, continued

Ana had been told her English was good, and it was. Under pressure she spoke it very fast — partly nerves, partly a wish to prove fluency.

A friend who sat through a practice interview told her something useful: the content was strong, and following it was hard work.

Ana slowed down deliberately. It felt, to her, unnaturally slow. To the listener it sounded measured.

Why it worked

This is one of the better-documented findings in the research, and it is not about prejudice. When speech is harder to process, listeners judge the content as less believable — researchers found this even when listeners knew the speaker had not written the words they were reading.

The mechanism is contested. The practical consequence is not. Anything that reduces the listener's effort works in your favour, and speed is the variable you control most easily.

Speaking faster does not demonstrate fluency. It spends your listener's attention on decoding rather than on your evidence.

Lev-Ari and Keysar, Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 2010. The size and mechanism of this effect remain debated; the practical advice does not depend on which side is right.

Your turn

Record thirty seconds at your normal pace. Record it again at a pace that feels too slow. Play both back.

CASE 16

The Pause

Bruno, continued

Bruno began answering the instant each question ended, because silence felt like failure. His answers started before he knew where they were going and often arrived somewhere he had not intended.

He gave himself permission to take two seconds. Sometimes he filled them out loud:

"Let me think about that for a moment."

Why it worked

Two seconds of silence feels enormous to the person in the chair and is barely noticed by the panel. What they notice is the answer, which is better for having been aimed.

The stated pause does something additional. It signals that you are considering the question rather than retrieving a memorized paragraph — and interviewers can tell the difference, and prefer the former.

Your turn

In your next practice session, count two beats before every answer. It will feel wrong. Do it anyway.

CASE 17

Signposting

Camila, continued

Camila's answers were complete but hard to follow. She would begin describing a situation, then double back to explain something she had skipped, then reach the result by a route the panel could not retrace.

She started announcing the shape first.

"There were two parts to this — the immediate problem, and then a change we made afterwards. Let me take them in order."

Why it worked

A listener who knows the shape of an answer can hold it. A listener who does not has to build the structure while also absorbing the content, and one of those tasks gets dropped.

For a panel scoring against a written guide, this is worth more still: you have told them where to write. And for a second-language speaker it functions as insurance — even if a sentence in the middle goes wrong, the panel still knows which part of the answer it belonged to.

Your turn

Add an opening line to your two longest stories that tells the listener how many parts are coming.

CASE 18

The Body He Could Sustain

Thiago, continued — interviewing at a Port of Vancouver freight forwarder

Thiago had been told to stop gesturing, so he sat on his hands. It made him look rigid and made speaking harder.

He had a second problem. He began the interview sitting upright and forward, and by the twenty-minute mark he had slumped onto the table, tired from holding a posture he could not maintain.

He fixed both by choosing positions he could hold for an hour rather than positions that looked alert for five minutes. Back against the chair, feet flat, forearms resting on the table. Hands wherever they went.

Why it worked

Advice about posture usually describes a photograph. An interview is not a photograph. It is forty-five minutes, and anything you cannot sustain will collapse visibly at the worst moment, which is usually the difficult question in the second half.

Suppressing gesture is the same mistake in a different form. It costs attention, and attention is what the answer needs. There is good evidence that gesture and speech are produced together, so interfering with one interferes with the other.

The real advice about hands is narrow: give them somewhere to rest so they are not searching, then stop managing them.

Your turn

Sit in your practice position for a full ten minutes. If you fidget, it is the wrong position.

CASE 19

Eye Contact Across a Panel

Patrícia, continued

Patrícia's first panel interview had three people. The one who asked the question was in the middle, so she answered the middle, and the other two spent four minutes being looked at by the side of her head.

She learned to start with the person who asked, move across the others during the answer, and finish with the asker.

Why it worked

In many panel processes every member scores independently. A panellist you have not looked at is a panellist forming an impression from your profile.

The rule is simple enough to follow while thinking about something else, which is the only kind of rule worth having in an interview. Start with the asker, include everyone, return to the asker.

Your turn

If you know it is a panel, practise the movement once. It is a physical habit, not an idea.

CASE 20

The Two Minutes Before the Interview

Larissa, continued

Larissa prepared thoroughly for the questions and not at all for the walk from the lobby. The receptionist asked whether she had found the building easily. She said yes. Silence followed them into the elevator.

She thought that part did not count.

Why it matters

It counts. Researchers scored candidates immediately after the informal opening chat, before any real question, and those early scores predicted final

interviewer ratings strongly. The effect tracked how verbally fluent and talkative the candidate was, independently of their qualifications.

This is not the myth that interviewers decide in seven seconds. They do not. But the small talk is not a waiting room; it is the first thing scored, and it is the part a second-language speaker cannot prepare answers for — because it is unpredictable in a way that competency questions are not.

You cannot script it. You can arrive with three ordinary things ready to say: the journey, the weather, something about the building.

Barrick, Swider and Stewart, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2010.

Your turn

Prepare three sentences of small talk. Yes, really. They are harder than the questions.

CASE 21

The Interview With No Interviewer

Larissa, continued — screening round for a coordinator role

Larissa was sent a link and told to complete her first-round interview by Friday. There was no time slot and no person. She would see a written question on screen, get sixty seconds to think, then two minutes to record an answer. Three questions. One take each.

She opened it on the Thursday evening without preparing, because she assumed it was a form.

It was not a form. There was no interviewer to read, no follow-up question to rescue a thin answer, no way to ask what a phrase meant, and no way to stop

and start again. She recorded three answers she knew were poor and could do nothing about it.

What she did the second time

She read the invitation properly and found what it told her: how many questions, how long to prepare, how long to answer, and how many attempts were allowed. Then she prepared for those specific constraints.

She wrote her four-word cards and put them on the wall directly behind the laptop, at eye level, so glancing at them did not look like glancing away. She practised finishing an answer in under ninety seconds, because a two-minute limit that cuts you off mid-sentence takes your result with it. And she recorded one practice answer in the actual software before starting the real thing.

Why it worked

The one-way video interview is the format most hostile to a second-language speaker, and it is becoming more common as a first-round screen. Everything that normally rescues you is absent. There is no rapport stage. There is nobody to say "could you rephrase that?" There is no follow-up question inviting you to add the detail you forgot.

What it rewards instead is exactly what can be prepared in advance — a known structure, a rehearsed opening sentence, and answers built to finish comfortably inside the limit rather than to fill it.

Treat the constraints as information. Most candidates never read them.

Your turn

Set a timer for ninety seconds and answer "tell me about a time you solved a difficult problem" into your phone. Finish before the timer. That is the skill.

CASE 22

The Camera at Eye Level

Marcela, continued

Marcela's video interview was conducted with the laptop on a low table. The camera looked up at her; she looked down at the panel; the window behind her turned her into a silhouette.

Her next one: laptop on a stack of books at eye level, a lamp in front of her, the window behind the screen instead of behind her head.

Why it worked

None of this is about looking attractive. It is about being easy to perceive. A dim, badly-angled image makes a listener work harder, and harder-to-process information is judged less favourably — the same effect that operates on accented speech operates on a bad picture.

Then there is the eyeline. If your camera is low, you are not making eye contact with anybody, no matter where you look. Raising it is a three-minute fix that most candidates never make.

Your turn

Open your camera app now. Raise the laptop until the lens is level with your eyes. Put a light in front of you.

CASE 23

Nerves Managed by Structure

Ana, continued

Ana had been told to relax and be confident, which is advice that has never helped anybody who was not already relaxed and confident.

What helped was different. She wrote the four beats of each story on a card — situation, task, action, result — and rehearsed until she could find the beats without the card. When the nerves came, she did not have to feel calm. She only had to remember what came next.

Why it worked

Interview anxiety is negatively related to interview performance, and telling somebody to feel differently is not an intervention. Structure is. When you know the shape of what you are about to say, nerves become an unpleasant sensation rather than an obstacle, because the retrieval no longer depends on your emotional state.

You do not need to be confident. You need to know what comes next.

Your turn

Reduce your three strongest stories to four words each — one per beat. Carry them in your head, not on paper.

CASE 24

Dressing for the Sector

Diego, continued — Kiewit site office

Diego wore a suit to an interview at a construction firm's site office. Everybody else was in work clothes. He spent the first ten minutes feeling conspicuous, which cost him more than the clothes did.

Before the next one he looked at the company's own photographs on its website and social media and dressed one step above what he saw.

Why it worked

The purpose of interview clothing is to be forgotten. Anything that makes you the most formally dressed person in the room, or the least, is spending attention that should be going to your answers — most of all your own.

"One step above the workplace norm" is a rule that travels across sectors. A health authority, a bank, a trades contractor and a tech company all have different norms, and all of them publish photographs.

Your turn

Look at the employer's own photographs. Dress one step up from what you see. Then stop thinking about it.

CASE 25

Arriving Early and Sitting in the Car

Camila, continued

Camila used to arrive fifteen minutes early and go straight in, then sit in a waiting room becoming more nervous.

She began arriving thirty minutes early and staying outside. Ten minutes in the car reading her four-word story cards. Then in, ten minutes before.

Why it worked

Arriving early removes the transport risk, which is a real risk. But a long wait inside is not neutral — it is time spent in an unfamiliar environment, being observed, with nothing to do.

Splitting the buffer keeps the safety margin and turns most of it into rehearsal time in a space you control. Ten minutes before is right; thirty is imposing on the receptionist and on yourself.

Your turn

Plan two arrival times: when you reach the area, and when you enter the building. They should be twenty minutes apart.

PART THREE

STRONG ANSWERS

Nineteen real questions.

Each case gives you a strong answer and then takes it apart. The point is not to memorize the answers — they are somebody else's experiences and will not fit you. The point is to see the machinery, so that you can build your own version out of your own material.

Read the answer first. Then read why it works. Then find the equivalent in your inventory.

CASE 26

"Tell me about yourself."

Camila, applying to Vancouver Coastal Health

> *"I trained and worked as a nurse in Brazil for nine years, mostly in a busy emergency department in Belo Horizonte, and my credential assessment here is in its final stage. Since arriving I've been working as a care aide at a private residence in Burnaby, which has taught me how care works here in ways I couldn't have learned from outside. What I'm looking for now is a role where I can use the acute care experience again. That's why this posting caught my attention."*

Why it is strong

Forty-five seconds. Three moves.

Where she has been — with a number and a specific setting, not "several years of healthcare experience."

Where she is now — including the care aide job, stated without apology and given a purpose: it taught her the system.

Where she is going, and why here — landing on the specific posting.

Notice what it does not contain. No childhood, no personality adjectives, no life story. This question is not an invitation to autobiography; it is the interviewer asking you to orient them. Candidates who take it as autobiography spend four minutes and arrive nowhere.

Notice also the last sentence. It hands the conversation back.

Your turn

Write your three moves. Time yourself. If you are past sixty seconds, cut the middle.

CASE 27

"Why do you want to work here?"

Larissa, applying to MOSAIC, a settlement non-profit in East Vancouver

> *"Two reasons. The practical one is that the role is coordination work and that's what I'm good at — I've been running volunteer scheduling for a language exchange for about a year and I like the puzzle of it. The other reason is more specific to you. I noticed you're expanding, and from the*

> *posting it looks like the scheduling is straining under that. That's the kind of problem I'd want to work on."*

Why it is strong

Most answers to this question are flattery — the organization's reputation, its values, its mission statement read back to it. Interviewers hear this constantly and it tells them nothing.

Larissa answers with a fit and a problem. The fit is evidenced, not claimed. The problem shows that she read the posting as information rather than as an advertisement.

The structure — "two reasons, one practical and one specific" — is signposting doing quiet work. The panel knows how long the answer will be before it starts.

Your turn

Write your two reasons. Delete any sentence that could be said to a competitor of theirs.

CASE 28

"Tell me about a difficult problem you solved."

Rafael, applying to a CPKC intermodal operation

> *"In my last role we had a recurring problem where orders for one client were arriving late — around a quarter of them, over about three months, and the client was starting to talk about the contract.*

> *I was asked to find out where the delay was. I pulled the dispatch records for ninety days and mapped where each late order had lost its time. Most of the delay wasn't in transport at all; it was sitting between order confirmation and picking, usually overnight.*
>
> *I set up a simple end-of-day check so that anything confirmed after four o'clock got flagged for the morning shift instead of waiting for someone to notice it. I also asked the client to send their large orders earlier in the day, which they were happy to do once they understood why.*
>
> *Late deliveries for that client dropped to under ten percent within about two months, and the contract was renewed."*

Why it is strong

Four beats, clearly separated: the problem with a size attached, his specific responsibility, what he personally did, and the result.

The most important word in the answer is **"I."** He pulled the records. He set up the check. He asked the client. Candidates frequently retreat into "we" — and a panel scoring individual competency cannot give marks to a team.

Notice the diagnosis. He does not say "I worked with the team to improve things." He says where the time was actually being lost, which proves he investigated rather than guessed. That single detail — the delay was not in transport — is what makes the whole answer credible.

And the result is measured, bounded and modest. Under ten percent, about two months. Not "we transformed the operation."

Your turn

Take your best problem story and write the four beats in four separate sentences. Check that beat three contains the word "I" at least twice.

CASE 29

"Tell me about a mistake you made."

Bruno, applying to Canadian Tire

> *"About a year into my supervisor role, I approved a stock order without checking it against what was already in the back. We ended up with roughly three times the seasonal stock we needed, and it tied up space and money for two months.*
>
> *I told my manager the same day rather than waiting for it to surface. We worked out a plan to move it — some of it went to another branch, some went into a promotion earlier than planned.*
>
> *Afterwards I started checking the back stock before approving anything, which sounds obvious, but it wasn't part of the process before. It became part of the process for the other two supervisors as well.*
>
> *We cleared most of it within about six weeks. It cost us margin on that line, though — I don't want to pretend it was free."*

Why it is strong

It is a real mistake. This is rarer than you would think, and it is the whole test. Candidates who answer with "I work too hard" or "I'm a perfectionist" are giving an answer interviewers have heard hundreds of times and do not believe.

There are three moves after the mistake, and they matter more than the mistake itself: he **disclosed it early**, he **fixed it**, and he **changed the process** so it could not recur. The change outlasting him — adopted by the other supervisors — is the strongest part of the answer.

Then the last line. He declines to make it a triumph. A candidate who admits the cost is telling you they can be trusted to report bad news, which is what this question is really asking.

Your turn

Write a real one. If your answer makes you look good with no cost attached, it is not yet an answer.

CASE 30

"Tell me about a conflict with a coworker."

Diego, applying to PCL Construction

> *"I was running a small crew on a residential job with a tight finish date, and one of the other supervisors and I disagreed about sequencing — he wanted his trades in before we'd finished, and I thought it would create rework.*
>
> *It got tense for a couple of days. What changed it was asking him to walk the site with me rather than arguing about it over the phone. Once we were both looking at the same rooms, it turned out we were worried about different things — he had a subcontractor availability problem I didn't know about.*
>
> *We split it. His people went into two of the units early, where it didn't matter, and waited on the other three. I adjusted my sequence for the two.*
>
> *We finished on the date. We used the same arrangement on the next job."*

Why it is strong

The other person is not made to look foolish. This is the trap in the conflict question, and most candidates walk into it — they describe a difficult

colleague and inadvertently demonstrate that they are the kind of person who describes colleagues as difficult.

Diego's version has a genuine disagreement between two people with reasonable positions. The turn in the story is that he **found out something he did not know**, which requires having asked.

Note the mechanism: walking the site instead of arguing on the phone. Not "I communicated openly." A specific act.

And a result on two levels — the job finished, and the working relationship survived well enough to be reused.

Your turn

Take your conflict story. Write the other person's side of it in one sentence, as they would have written it. If you cannot, you do not understand the conflict yet.

CASE 31

"Tell me about a time you worked under pressure."

Ana, applying to Providence Health Care

> *"During a bad flu season we had two nurses out sick on the same shift, on a night with a full department. We were three people covering what was normally five.*
>
> *My responsibility was the acute side. What I did first was triage the whole board — I went through every patient and sorted them into who needed attention within the hour, who could wait, and who was stable enough to be checked at handover. Then I told the other two which category they were*

> *working from, so nobody was making that decision individually while under pressure.*
>
> *I also called the on-call coordinator early, about two hours before I thought we'd be in trouble, rather than at the point where we were.*
>
> *We got through the shift without an incident. Two patients waited longer than I'd have liked and I flagged both at handover."*

Why it is strong

The scale is established before the action: three people doing the work of five, on a full night. Without that, "I worked under pressure" is a claim about her feelings.

The action has a method — triage, communicate the method to others, escalate early. Notice that the escalation is presented as a strength, not a failure. Calling for help two hours before you need it is judgment. Many candidates hide this, thinking it makes them look unable to cope.

And she names what did not go perfectly, at the end, briefly. In healthcare in particular this is the answer to the real question, which is whether she will tell you when something goes wrong.

Your turn

Find your pressure story and write the size of it first. How many people, how much work, how much time.

CASE 32

"Tell me about a time you showed leadership."

Marcela, applying to ICBC

> *"I wasn't a manager, but I was the longest-serving person in a team of six when our department got a new document system with about a month's notice.*
>
> *Nobody had been assigned to handle the transition, and I could see it was going to land badly — two of my colleagues were quite anxious about it. So I asked our manager if I could take it on.*
>
> *I went through the training material first, made a two-page guide for the six things we actually did every day rather than everything the system could do, and ran three short sessions instead of one long one, because I thought people would absorb it better in pieces.*
>
> *By the switchover we were all working in it. The two-page guide got picked up by another department and it's still what new hires get."*

Why it is strong

She was not in charge, and she says so in the first line. Leadership questions do not require a title, and candidates who think they do miss the question entirely. What is required is that something happened because you decided it should.

The volunteering is the hinge — "nobody had been assigned" and "I asked if I could take it on." Everything after that is initiative rather than duty.

The judgment shows in the details: six tasks rather than the whole system, three short sessions rather than one long one. Those are decisions, and each one has a reason attached.

The guide surviving her is the result. A thing that outlasts you is the strongest evidence of leadership available.

Your turn

Find a time you took something on that was not yours. That is your leadership story, whatever your job title was.

CASE 33

"Tell me about a time you improved a process."

Thiago, applying to a TransLink contractor

> *"In my department, two people were spending most of a morning each week entering the same delivery information into our system and into the client's portal — the same data, twice, by hand.*
>
> *It wasn't anybody's job to fix it, but it was costing us roughly eight hours a week between them.*
>
> *I mapped what was actually being duplicated — it turned out to be four fields, not the whole record — and took it to our IT contact with a specific request rather than a complaint. He built an export that covered three of the four. The fourth still had to be done manually because the portal wouldn't accept it.*
>
> *It took the weekly job from about eight hours to under two."*

Why it is strong

The cost comes before the fix. Eight hours a week is what makes the story worth telling; without it, "I improved a process" describes anything at all.

The best line is *"a specific request rather than a complaint."* That is the difference between an employee who identifies problems and one who solves them, and it is stated without boasting because the story demonstrates it.

Then the honest limit: three fields out of four. The fourth was not solvable. Candidates who report total victories are less believable than candidates who report partial ones, because real improvements are almost always partial.

Your turn

Find a piece of waste you have seen at work. Write down what it costs per week. That number is your opening line.

CASE 34

"Tell me about a difficult customer or patient."

Ana, applying to Fraser Health

> *"A patient's daughter became very angry at the desk because her mother had been waiting a long time and nobody had updated her. She was raising her voice in a corridor with other patients in it.*
>
> *The first thing I did was move the conversation — I asked her to come into a side room, partly for privacy and partly because standing in a corridor was making it worse. Then I let her finish. I didn't explain anything until she'd stopped.*
>
> *When she was done, I told her what I actually knew: her mother had been assessed, she was stable, and the delay was for a scan that was backed up. I didn't have a time, so I said I didn't have a time, and I said I'd come back within thirty minutes whether or not I had news.*
>
> *I went back at twenty-five minutes. She was calmer. She apologized, which she didn't need to do."*

Why it is strong

The actions are physical and specific: move the location, let her finish, do not explain into an interruption, promise a return and keep it early.

The strongest element is refusing to invent a time. Candidates often reach for reassurance in these stories. Ana reports saying "I don't have a time" and then giving something she could actually control — when she would return. That is a real technique, and it is the one that resolved the situation.

The last line is a light touch. She does not claim the apology as a victory. She notes it and moves on.

Your turn

Take your difficult-person story and remove every sentence about how you felt. What is left should still be a complete answer.

CASE 35

"Tell me about a time you had to learn something quickly."

Larissa, applying to a Vancouver arts organization

> *"When I took over the volunteer roster, it was in a spreadsheet that had grown to about seventy people and had stopped working — double bookings most weeks.*
>
> *I'd never used any scheduling software. I gave myself a weekend. I watched the tutorials for the free version of one tool, imported the seventy names to see what would break, and it broke immediately because the phone number format was inconsistent. So I learned enough about find-and-replace to clean that up.*

> *By the Monday I had it running. It wasn't elegant. But double bookings went from three or four a week to none in the first month.*
>
> *I also wrote down what I'd done, because I knew I'd forget it, and that ended up being the handover document."*

Why it is strong

The learning is described as a process rather than as a trait. Candidates who say "I'm a fast learner" have said nothing. Larissa describes what she actually did over a weekend, including the part where it broke.

The failure detail — the phone number format — is what makes it real. Nobody invents that.

"It wasn't elegant" is honest and costs her nothing. The result is measured. And the handover document at the end shows a second quality nobody asked about: she thinks past her own involvement.

Your turn

Find something you learned under time pressure. Include the part where it did not work.

CASE 36

"Tell me about a time you raised a safety concern."

Diego, applying to EllisDon

> *"We were on a site where a temporary guardrail on the second floor had been moved to get material through and hadn't gone back up properly — it was in place but not fixed at one end.*

> *I noticed it late in the day. The easy thing would have been to mention it in the morning, because nobody was working on that level.*
>
> *I didn't. I stopped what I was doing, taped it off, and called the site supervisor that evening. He got it re-fixed before the next shift started.*
>
> *He also asked me to raise it at the toolbox talk, which I did, and we changed the rule so that whoever moves a rail owns putting it back — before, it was nobody's specifically."*

Why it is strong

The temptation is stated out loud. *"The easy thing would have been to mention it in the morning."* Naming the shortcut and then declining it is far more convincing than simply reporting correct behaviour, because it shows the decision actually happened.

The action is immediate and physical: stop, tape, call. Not "I raised it through the appropriate channel."

And the outcome changes the system, not just the rail. Whoever moves it owns putting it back. For employers in safety-critical sectors — utilities, construction, transport, health — this is the answer to the question they are actually asking, which is whether you will speak up when it is inconvenient.

Your turn

Find a time you did the harder correct thing. Write down what the easy alternative was.

CASE 37

"Tell me about handling confidential information."

Camila, applying to the Provincial Health Services Authority

> *"In the emergency department we had a case involving someone locally known, and there was pressure — not from management, from curiosity. Staff who had no clinical reason to be involved were asking.*
>
> *What I did was straightforward. I didn't discuss it, including with colleagues I trusted, and when I was asked directly I said I couldn't talk about it rather than pretending I didn't know. I think that matters — pretending ignorance is its own kind of dishonesty and it invites another question.*
>
> *I also raised with my charge nurse that the record was being accessed more than the case warranted, because that's auditable and I didn't want it to become a problem for the department.*
>
> *The access was restricted the same day."*

Why it is strong

She describes a real pressure, and locates it accurately — curiosity, not instruction. Interviewers know that the realistic threat to confidentiality is social, not malicious.

The technique is specific and unusually good: refusing to discuss rather than feigning ignorance, with a reason attached. That reason shows a candidate who has thought about it rather than memorized a policy.

Escalating the access issue is the second half, and it is what separates a discreet employee from an accountable one. She protected the information and the department.

Your turn

Confidentiality answers need one concrete moment. Find yours — a document, a conversation, a record, a message that was not yours to share.

CASE 38

"How do you handle competing deadlines?"

Rafael, applying to a Port of Vancouver terminal operator

> *"I'll give you a specific week. I had a client audit due Thursday, a supplier contract to renew by Friday, and my two-person team lost one of them to illness on the Tuesday.*
>
> *The first thing I did was find out which deadlines were real. The audit was fixed — regulatory. The contract had a stated Friday date but the supplier had been flexible before, so I called them and asked directly. They gave me until Wednesday the following week without much difficulty.*
>
> *That turned three problems into two. I took the audit myself because it needed the most context, and gave my remaining colleague the routine dispatch work so nothing slipped on the operational side.*
>
> *Audit went in Thursday. Contract signed the following Tuesday. Nothing was late that actually had a hard date."*

Why it is strong

The method is the answer, and the method has a first step most people skip: **find out which deadlines are real.** Candidates usually describe prioritizing among fixed constraints. Rafael describes testing the constraints first, which is what competent people actually do.

Making the phone call is the specific act. It is small and it removed a third of the problem.

The last line is precise: *nothing was late that actually had a hard date.* He does not claim everything was delivered on time, because it was not. He claims the right thing.

Your turn

Think of your worst week. Which deadline turned out to be softer than it looked, and how did you find out?

CASE 39

"Tell me about a time you disagreed with your manager."

Marcela, applying to the Government of Canada

> *"My manager wanted to move our filing deadline forward by a week to give herself buffer before a board meeting. I thought it would cause errors, because the last week is when most of the corrections come in.*
>
> *I said so, once, in a one-on-one rather than in the team meeting. I brought the numbers — in the previous three cycles, between eleven and fifteen percent of records had changed in that final week.*
>
> *She listened and decided to do it anyway, because the board meeting mattered more to her than it did to me, and she had context I didn't.*

> *So I did it. What I asked for instead was a correction window after submission, which she agreed to, and we used it. About twelve percent of the records were amended, which was roughly what I'd expected."*

Why it is strong

She lost, and she reports losing. This is the answer most candidates avoid, and it is the strongest available, because the question is not testing whether you are right. It is testing whether you can be overruled and remain useful.

The disagreement is handled well on three counts: privately rather than publicly, once rather than repeatedly, and with evidence rather than opinion.

Then the crucial move — she does not merely comply, she proposes a mitigation. The correction window is a person still solving the problem after losing the argument.

And she grants her manager legitimate reasons she was not party to. That is generosity, and it reads as maturity.

Your turn

Find a disagreement you lost. That is your answer, not the one you won.

CASE 40

"Tell me about working with people very different from you."

Camila, applying to the University of British Columbia

> *"In my last department, I worked most closely with a physiotherapist and an administrator, and the three of us wanted completely different things from*

> *the same patient discharge process. I wanted clinical detail recorded. He wanted mobility notes that made sense to him. She wanted it done in a form that took under four minutes.*
>
> *We were mildly annoyed with each other for a while.*
>
> *What worked was building the form together in one sitting instead of sending versions back and forth. Once we were in the same room, it became obvious that the clinical detail I wanted and the mobility notes he wanted were mostly the same information described in different vocabularies.*
>
> *The form got shorter and it captured more. It took about four and a half minutes, which she accepted."*

Why it is strong

The differences are professional rather than demographic, and each position is described as reasonable. Nobody in this story is being difficult; three people want three legitimate things.

"We were mildly annoyed with each other for a while" is a small line doing real work. It is honest, and it is proportionate — the answer is not sanitized into a story where everyone was delightful.

The discovery is specific: the same information in different vocabularies. That is what actually happens when specialists collide, and recognizing it is the skill being tested.

And the result is honest to the half-minute. Four and a half, not four.

Your turn

Find people who wanted different things from the same work. That is the answer. It does not have to be about background.

CASE 41

"Where do you see yourself in five years?"

Bruno, applying to Save-On-Foods

> *"Honestly, my five-year picture has changed a lot since I arrived, so I'll tell you what I'm confident about and what I'm not.*
>
> *What I'm confident about is that I want to stay in operations and I want to be managing a site rather than a section. I've done the section part and I know I like it.*
>
> *What I'm less sure about is the sector. I've only worked retail here, and I'm curious whether the same skills work in distribution. I'd want to find that out inside a company rather than by leaving one.*
>
> *For this role specifically — I'd want two or three years doing it well before I asked for anything else."*

Why it is strong

He answers the question. Many candidates deflect this one into flattery about the company, and the interviewer learns nothing.

Splitting into confident and uncertain is both honest and structurally clear. It allows genuine ambition — site management — without pretending to a plan he does not have.

The last line is the one that matters to the employer. It answers the unspoken worry, which is whether they are about to train somebody who leaves in eight months. He addresses it without being asked and without promising forever.

Your turn

Write what you are sure of and what you are not. Then add one sentence about this job specifically.

CASE 42

"What is your greatest weakness?"

Thiago, applying to BC Hydro

> *"I'm slow to delegate. When something is complicated I tend to keep it, because it's faster in the moment to do it than to explain it.*
>
> *I noticed it properly about two years ago when I was the only person who understood our supplier tracking, and I couldn't take a week off without it degrading. That was my fault, not anyone else's.*
>
> *What I've done since is force it — I pick one thing a month that I'd normally keep and hand it over properly, with documentation, even when it costs me time that week. The supplier tracking is now run by two other people.*
>
> *I'd still say it's my instinct. I just don't act on it as much."*

Why it is strong

It is a real weakness with a real cost, and the cost is stated: he could not take a week off. Candidates who offer a disguised strength — "I care too much," "I'm a perfectionist" — are giving an answer that interviewers recognize instantly as evasion.

He takes ownership without drama. *"That was my fault, not anyone else's."*

The remedy is a specific mechanism, not an intention. One thing a month, documented, even when inconvenient. And there is evidence it worked.

The final line is why the answer is trusted. He does not claim to be cured. Weaknesses that vanish completely are not weaknesses; they are marketing.

Your turn

Name a real one. Then name the mechanism, not the intention. Then admit it is still there.

CASE 43

"There's a gap in your employment. Can you explain it?"

Patrícia, returning after two years

> *"Yes. I arrived in Canada in 2023, and I spent the first two years settling my family and completing my credential assessment, which took longer than I expected. I started looking for work in March.*
>
> *I did keep my hand in — I volunteered two mornings a week at a settlement organization doing intake, which is where most of my Canadian references come from.*
>
> *I'm ready to start full time now."*

Why it is strong

Short. The length of a gap explanation signals how much of a problem the candidate believes it to be, and a defensive four-paragraph justification creates a doubt that two flat sentences would have avoided.

The gap has content. Settling children, completing an assessment, volunteering — the period is accounted for rather than empty.

The volunteering is placed strategically, as evidence rather than as an excuse, and it produces something the employer values: local references.

And the final sentence answers the practical question behind the gap — whether she is available now — before anyone has to ask it. She closes the subject on her own terms.

Your turn

Write your gap in three sentences: what the period was for, what you did in it, and that you are ready now.

CASE 44

"Do you have any questions for us?"

Ana, applying to Vancouver Coastal Health

> *"Three, if there's time.*
>
> *First — what does the first ninety days look like for someone coming into this role? I'm trying to understand what I'd be expected to be handling alone by the end of it.*
>
> *Second — you mentioned the unit has been short-staffed. Is that being addressed by recruitment, or is the workload being redesigned? I ask because they're quite different experiences to walk into.*
>
> *And third — what does someone do in this job that makes you think, that person is going to be fine here?"*

Why it is strong

This is not the end of the interview; it is the last scored section, and candidates who say "no, you've covered everything" have declined to answer a question.

The first question is about performance expectations, which signals that she is thinking about doing the job rather than getting it.

The second is the strong one. It refers back to something the interviewer said, which proves she was listening, and it asks about a real difficulty without complaint. It also gets her genuine information she needs, which is the point.

The third invites the panel to describe success, and people enjoy answering it. It is also useful — the answer tells you what the job actually rewards.

None of these can be found on the website. That is the test for a good question.

Your turn

Prepare four questions, expect to ask two, and make at least one of them impossible to answer from the organization's own web page.

PART FOUR

THE WHOLE INTERVIEW

The answers are not the only thing being assessed.

Eight cases about what happens around them — the follow-up questions, the moment you do not understand, the experience you do not have, and what you do in the week before and the week after.

CASE 45

The Follow-Up Question

Rafael, continued

Rafael finished a strong four-beat answer and relaxed. Then the interviewer said: *"You mentioned you mapped where the delays were. How did you do that?"*

He had not prepared a second layer. He answered vaguely and watched a good answer lose its footing.

He prepared differently afterwards. For each story he wrote three likely follow-ups and one sentence for each: how did you find that out, why did you choose that option, what would you do differently.

Why it worked

Interviewers probe, and probing is not skepticism — it is how a structured interview separates a candidate who did the thing from a candidate who has learned to describe it.

A prepared candidate expects the second question and treats it as an opportunity, because it is the point at which the panel is asking for more detail rather than moving on.

The three probes are almost always the same three. How do you know, why that choice, what would you change.

Your turn

For each of your six stories, write one sentence answering "how did you find that out?"

CASE 46

When She Did Not Understand the Question

Larissa, continued

An interviewer asked Larissa about "managing up." She did not know the phrase. She guessed, answered something adjacent, and could tell from the follow-up that she had missed.

The next time she did not know a phrase, she said:

"I want to make sure I answer the right question — when you say 'managing up,' do you mean how I work with my manager?"

The interviewer clarified. She answered well.

Why it worked

Guessing is the expensive option. A wrong answer costs the whole question; a clarification costs eight seconds and demonstrates something employers actively want, which is a person who checks rather than assumes.

The phrasing matters. *"I want to make sure I answer the right question"* frames the request as precision rather than as a gap in English. Every panel has watched candidates answer the question they wished had been asked, and they are relieved when somebody checks.

You do not need perfect English. You need to be understood, and to make sure you have understood.

Your turn

Learn one sentence by heart. *"Could you say a little more about what you mean by that?"* Have it ready.

CASE 47

When He Did Not Have the Experience

Bruno, continued — Best Buy

Bruno was asked about experience with inventory management software he had never used. He had two bad options in front of him: pretend, or apologize.

He took a third.

"I haven't used that specific system. I've used two others — I learned the second one in about a week because the logic was similar. What I'd want to know is whether yours is doing anything unusual, because if it's standard I'd expect to be productive quite quickly."

Why it worked

Three moves in fifteen seconds: an honest no, adjacent evidence with a timeframe attached, and a question that turns a deficit into a conversation.

The evidence is the load-bearing part. "I'm a fast learner" is a claim; "I learned the second one in about a week" is a fact with a number, and it makes the same point without asking to be believed.

Ending on a question also changes the dynamic. The interviewer is now describing their system rather than recording a gap.

Your turn

List the requirements you do not meet. For each, write your nearest adjacent experience and how long it took you to pick it up.

CASE 48

The Panel and the Scoring Sheet

Camila, continued

Camila noticed that the three panellists were writing, and that they wrote most when she reached a result. She noticed that one of them was following a printed page and ticking.

She adjusted mid-interview. She slowed slightly at the results. She left a beat at the end of each answer instead of continuing into the silence.

Why it worked

In most formal processes — government, health authorities, universities, Crown corporations — each panellist scores independently against a written

guide, often built directly from the competencies in the posting. The pen is telling you where the marks are.

Speaking at a pace people can write down is a real advantage, and it costs nothing. So does stopping cleanly, because a candidate who keeps talking into the gap frequently talks over their own best point.

Structured interviews of this type are the most accurate selection method in the research literature — and the format that rewards preparation most. Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2022.

Your turn

Practise finishing an answer and then stopping. Count two seconds. It is harder than it sounds.

CASE 49

The Reference in Curitiba

Ana, continued

Ana was asked for two references. Her strongest was her former head nurse in Curitiba — five years of close working knowledge, and almost no English.

Her first instinct was to leave him off and use two Canadian people who barely knew her.

Instead she prepared him. She called and asked whether he was willing. She sent him, in Portuguese, the job title, a short description of the role, and the three things she hoped he might speak to. She warned him the call would come from Canada, that it would probably be early evening his time, and that it was fine to say he would prefer to answer in writing.

Then she told the employer, before they asked:

> *"One of my references is in Brazil and is four or five hours ahead, depending on the season. His English is limited, so he has offered to reply in writing if that's easier — or we can arrange a call with an independent interpreter, whichever you prefer."*

Why it worked

A reference who is surprised by the call gives a poor reference, however good their opinion of you. This is true in any language and much truer across a time zone and a language barrier.

The three things she asked him to speak to are the important part. Not a script — a reminder of which of her qualities were relevant to this specific role, from a man who last worked with her three years ago and remembers a hundred other nurses.

Flagging the difficulty in advance turns a problem into competence. An employer who dials an unreachable number in Brazil and gets nothing has learned something about how organized you are. An employer told beforehand, with two workable options offered, has also learned something about how organized you are — the opposite thing.

Your turn

Contact your overseas reference before you need them. Send the job description and three reminders. Tell them what time the call may come.

CASE 50

The Note Afterwards

Marcela, continued

Marcela sent a thank-you email that said thank you and nothing else. It was polite and had no effect.

Her next one was four sentences. Thanks. One specific thing from the conversation. One piece of information she had not managed to give — a certificate she had completed that had not come up. A short closing line.

Why it worked

A note that only says thank you is a formality. A note that adds one piece of evidence is a second, smaller interview.

The specific reference proves she was present in the conversation rather than sending a template. The additional information is the real function: interviews run out of time, and there is almost always something you did not get to say.

Four sentences. Within a day. Not a second attempt at the whole interview.

Your turn

Draft your note before the interview, with a blank space for the specific detail. Fill it the same evening.

CASE 51

The Rejection That Became the Next Interview

Diego, continued

Diego was rejected after a second-round interview. He replied once:

"Thanks for letting me know. If you have a moment, I'd value knowing what would have made me a stronger candidate — I'm going to keep applying in this sector and it would genuinely help."

The hiring manager answered. Diego had been vague on scheduling and cost control, and the successful candidate had been specific.

Four months later the same firm had another opening. Diego applied, mentioned the earlier process, and had a much better answer ready.

Why it worked

Most rejected candidates disappear, so the ones who ask stand out — and asking well, without argument or wounded pride, leaves the door open.

The reply also produced the single most valuable thing available to him: specific information about where he was weak, from someone who watched him compete against a stronger candidate. That is worth more than another five applications.

Not everyone answers. It costs one email to find out.

Your turn

Write your feedback request now, before you need it. It is much harder to write on the day you are rejected.

CASE 52

The Week Before

All of them

Every person in this book prepared. None of them prepared everything.

Here is what a workable week looks like.

Seven days before. Print the posting. One line per requirement. Write the story you would use beside each. Find the empty lines — that is what the week is for.

Five days before. Choose six stories, not twelve. Reduce each to four words: situation, task, action, result.

Four days before. Say them out loud, standing up. The third telling is the one that counts.

Three days before. Record one. Watch it once. Write down one habit. Do not try to fix everything.

Two days before. Write the follow-ups — how did you find that out, why that choice, what would you change. One sentence each.

The day before. Prepare the small things. Three sentences of small talk. Four questions to ask them. Your salary floor. The route, and two arrival times twenty minutes apart. Then stop. Nothing learned on the last evening survives the room.

The morning of. Read your four-word cards once. Not the full stories.

Why it works

Preparation is often described as though it were a moral quality — how badly you want it, how hard you are willing to work. It is not. It is a set of specific tasks, most of them small, spread across a week so that none of them has to be done under pressure.

And it is not cheating. Researchers have tested whether coaching candidates damages the accuracy of a structured interview, on the reasonable theory that a rehearsed candidate is a disguised one. They found the opposite: interviews with prepared candidates were *more* accurate, not less.

The reason is simple. A person who cannot retrieve their own experience under pressure is not being seen clearly. They are being seen badly.

Preparation does not hide you.

It is what lets them see you.

Maurer, Solamon and Lippstreu, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2008.

PART FIVE

THE PORTUGUESE SECTION

The rest of this book would work for anyone.

This part would not. It is written for one reader: a Brazilian preparing to be interviewed in English, in Canada.

There are four chapters. The first two are about language, and they are the most valuable pages in the book, because no interview book written for a general audience can contain them. The third is about the document that gets you into the room. The fourth is about what different employers are actually testing.

None of these are case studies. They are reference chapters. Use them the way you would use a dictionary.

CHAPTER A

THE WORDS THAT CHANGE YOUR MEANING

Some English words look exactly like Portuguese words and mean something else.

This is not a matter of sounding foreign. Some of them change the meaning of what you are saying — and the interviewer will not stop to check, because they have no idea a translation has taken place. They will simply write down something you did not mean.

I have put the ones that matter most first.

◆

Tier One: These change what you are saying

colégio → secondary school, not "college"

The most costly error in this chapter.

In Brazil, *colégio* is high school. In Canada, "college" is post-secondary — a diploma-granting institution. When you write "College" on a résumé or say "I finished college in Brazil," a Canadian reader hears a post-secondary credential you do not have.

When it comes up later, it is read as an exaggeration rather than as a translation.

> *Say: **"I finished secondary school in Brazil in 2009."***

The same care applies further up. *Graduação* is an undergraduate degree — say "bachelor's degree." *Pós-graduação* in Brazil often means a specialization certificate rather than a master's; if that is what you hold, say "a postgraduate specialization, not a master's." Say it early and it never becomes a question.

pretender → to intend, not "to pretend"

> *"I pretend to work in healthcare."*

In English this says you are only acting the part. It is one of the easiest to fix and one of the most worth fixing.

> *Say: **"I intend to work in healthcare"** — or better, **"I want to."***

atualmente → currently, not "actually"

> *"Actually I work in logistics."*

In English, "actually" corrects something. The interviewer will hear you contradicting them and will spend a moment working out what they got wrong.

> *Say: **"Currently I work in logistics."** Or **"Right now."***

prejuízo → loss or damage, not "prejudice"

> *"The delay caused a lot of prejudice to the company."*

"Prejudice" in English means bias against a group of people. In a Canadian workplace context this word carries weight you do not want near an unrelated sentence about a shipping delay.

> *Say: **"The delay caused significant losses."***

compromisso → commitment or appointment, not "compromise"

> *"I had a compromise that morning."*

"Compromise" means giving up part of what you wanted. Saying you compromised on a standard means something quite different from saying you had an appointment.

> *Say: **"I had a prior commitment."***

atender → to serve, to help, or to answer, not "to attend"

Critical if you are interviewing in retail, hospitality, healthcare or any customer-facing role — which is most first jobs in Canada.

> *"I attended more than fifty customers a day."*

In English you attend a meeting or a school. You do not attend a person.

> *Say: **"I served more than fifty customers a day."** Or **"I helped."** For the telephone: **"I answered calls."***

eventualmente → occasionally, not "eventually"

> *"I eventually covered the night shift."*

You mean you did it from time to time. The interviewer hears that you did it *in the end*, after some delay — which suggests reluctance.

> *Say: **"I occasionally covered the night shift."** Or **"From time to time."***

estágio → internship or placement, not "stage"

> *Say: **"I did a six-month internship at..."***

assistir → to watch or to attend, not "to assist"

> *"I assisted the training session."*

You mean you were there. The interviewer hears that you helped run it — a claim you did not intend to make and may not be able to support under a follow-up question.

> *Say: **"I attended the training."** If you did help: **"I helped deliver the training."***

◆

Tier Two: These are worth an hour of your time

These are smaller slips, but some of them can still change your meaning. They are worth an hour.

YOU MAY SAY	THE INTERVIEWER HEARS	SAY INSTEAD
"I cannot **support** that pressure"	You won't back it	"I can **handle** that pressure"
"My manager was very **comprehensive**"	Thorough, extensive	"My manager was very **understanding**"
"He is very **educated**"	Well-schooled	"He is very **polite**" / "well-mannered"
"I **realized** the project"	You became aware of it	"I **completed** / **carried out** the project"
"Our **collaborators**"	Outside partners	"Our **employees**" / "our **staff**"
"I worked in a **fabric**"	Cloth	"I worked in a **factory**"
	The information	"What is the **date**?"

YOU MAY SAY	THE INTERVIEWER HEARS	SAY INSTEAD
"What is the **data** of the meeting?"		
"It was a **particular** company"	Unusual, specific	"It was a **private** company"
"The process was **esquisito**" → "exquisite"	Beautiful, refined	"The process was **strange**"
"I have a **formation** in nursing"	—	"I have **training** / a **qualification** in nursing"
"My **cargo** was supervisor"	Freight	"My **position** / **role** was supervisor"
"I need to **recall** the details"	Retrieve from memory	"I need to **remember**" (usually fine — but *recordar* is remember, not record)

◆

Tier Three: The grammar habits

These do not change your meaning. They accumulate, and accumulation is what makes a listener work harder — which, as Chapter B explains, costs you credibility you have not done anything to deserve losing.

Uncountable nouns. English refuses to pluralize these:

> ~~*informations*~~ → ***information*** ~~*advices*~~ → ***advice*** ~~*knowledges*~~ → ***knowledge*** ~~*feedbacks*~~ → ***feedback*** ~~*equipments*~~ → ***equipment*** ~~*trainings*~~ → ***training*** ~~*staffs*~~ → ***staff*** ~~*softwares*~~ → ***software***

Verb partnerships. English pairs verbs and nouns differently:

> ~~*take a decision*~~ → ***make a decision*** ~~*make a course*~~ → ***take a course*** ~~*make a question*~~ → ***ask a question*** ~~*take a coffee*~~ → ***have a coffee*** ~~*do a mistake*~~ → ***make a mistake*** ~~*make an interview*~~ → ***have an interview*** *(the employer conducts it)*

Age. *Tenho 35 anos* becomes:

> ~~*"I have 35 years"*~~ → ***"I am 35."***

Duration. *Há dois anos* becomes:

> ~~*"I work here since two years"*~~ → ***"I have worked here for two years."*** ~~*"Since 2019"*~~ *is correct — use since with a point in time, for with a length of time.*

Agreement. *Estou de acordo* becomes:

> ~~*"I am agree"*~~ → ***"I agree."***

Experience. Word order:

> ~~*"I have experience of ten years"*~~ → ***"I have ten years of experience."***

◆

The one-hour exercise

Do not try to learn this chapter.

Take your six stories. Read them out loud once, watching only for the words on these lists. Mark every one you find. Most people find between four and nine, and they are the same four to nine every time — you have personal false friends, not general ones.

Fix those. Ignore the rest of the chapter.

CHAPTER B

BEING EASY TO HEAR

This chapter is not about losing your accent.

Keep your accent. It is not a defect, employers in Vancouver hear dozens of them every week, and trying to sound Canadian is an enormous amount of work for no benefit.

This chapter is about something narrower and much more useful: **the specific things Brazilian speakers do in English that make a listener work harder**, and the two or three that are worth fixing.

Why this matters more than it should

Researchers asked native English speakers to judge whether ordinary factual statements were true. The same statements were recorded by native speakers and by speakers with foreign accents. Listeners were told the speakers had not written the statements — they were only reading them aloud.

The accented statements were judged less true anyway.

The proposed explanation is that when something is harder to process, it feels less believable. Researchers still argue about the mechanism, and you should know that. But the practical consequence is not in dispute, and it is entirely in your hands.

You are not trying to sound native. You are trying to reduce the number of calories your listener burns.

Lev-Ari and Keysar, Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 2010.

◆

The five that cost the most

1. The extra vowel at the end — *the big one*

Portuguese does not like words ending in consonants, so a small /i/ sound gets added:

> *"Facebook" → Facebook-ee "hot dog" → hot dog-ee "I work" → I work-ee "big" → big-ee*

This is the single most expensive habit, because it happens on almost every word and adds a syllable each time. A sentence with eight consonant-final words becomes eight syllables longer than the listener expects, and they spend the whole sentence resynchronizing.

How to practise: take ten words ending in hard consonants — *work, help, hard, project (PRO-ject, the noun), result, client, product, staff, night, shift* — and say each one, stopping your mouth. Feel the ending stop. Record it. You will hear the extra vowel immediately, and once you hear it you can stop it.

2. The -ed ending

Past tense endings in English are usually one sound, not one syllable:

> *"worked" = workt — one syllable, not work-ed-ee "helped" = helpt "asked" = askt "finished" = finisht "managed" = managd*

Only after a *t* or *d* sound does -ed become a syllable: *wanted*, *needed*, *decided*.

This matters double in a behavioural interview, because you will be speaking in the past tense for forty-five minutes. Every story you tell is made of these verbs.

3. ship / sheep — the vowel that creates real confusion

English distinguishes a short / / from a long /i /. Portuguese does not, so these become the same word:

> ***live / leave*** *— "I live in Surrey" versus "I leave in Surrey"* ***ship / sheep fill / feel bit / beat sit / seat it / eat this / these***

Unlike the others in this chapter, this one produces genuine misunderstandings rather than extra effort. "I've been living here for two years" and "I've been leaving here for two years" are different claims.

The trick: the short one is shorter *and* the mouth is more relaxed. Make a shorter, more relaxed vowel, slightly toward the "e" in "bed."

4. The th sounds

> *"think" → sink or tink "the" → de "with" → wiv or wit "three" → tree*

Honestly: this is the one I would fix last. It is very recognizable, but it rarely causes actual confusion, because context resolves it. Native English speakers from many places do not produce these sounds either.

Fix it if you have time. Fix the extra vowel first.

5. Word stress

English words carry one strong syllable, and putting it in the wrong place is more disruptive than getting the sounds wrong:

> ***COM**-fort-able (not com-FOR T-able) **NEC**-ess-ary **MAN**-age-ment ex-**PER**-i-ence re-**SPON**-si-ble **CAT**-e-gory ad-**MIN**-is-trative*

Take the fifteen words you will use most in your interview — your job title, your industry, your core skills — and check the stress on each one. Fifteen words. It is a twenty-minute job and it affects every sentence you speak.

◆

What to actually do

Not all of it. Two things:

One. Record yourself telling one story. Listen for the extra vowel at the ends of words. That alone will do more than everything else in this chapter combined.

Two. Slow down. Every problem in this chapter gets smaller at a slower pace, and pace costs nothing to change.

CHAPTER C

YOUR RESUME: REMOVE AND INCLUDE

Your Brazilian *currículo* will need to be modified before you send it to a Canadian employer.

The conventions are simply different. Some things that belong on a currículo in Brazil are left off here, and some things Canadian employers expect to see are not on it yet.

Two lists. That is the whole chapter.

◆

REMOVE

- **The photograph.** Normal in Brazil. Not used in Canada.
- **Date of birth and age.**
- **Marital status, children, and dependants.**
- **Gender.**
- **CPF, RG, passport or any identity document number.**
- **Nationality.**
- **Your full street address.** City and province is enough — *Surrey, BC*.
- **Religion and health information.**
- **A signature.**
- **A long "Objective" paragraph** about what you are seeking.
- **Duties without results.** "Responsible for scheduling" says nothing.
- **References and their contact details.** Bring them separately when asked.

- **Anything over two pages.**

◆

INCLUDE

- **A Canadian-format phone number** — (604) 555-0134.
- **A professional email address** — your name, not a nickname.
- **City and province** at the top.
- **A two- or three-line summary** of what you are and what you are looking for. This is the written version of Case 26.
- **A descriptor line under every employer nobody here has heard of.** Fifteen words, with a size and a comparison:

> ***Transportes Camargo*** *— a leading distribution company in the Campinas region, approximately 800 employees Night Operations Supervisor, 2018–2022*

- **Numbers in your achievements.** Six staff. Three minutes down to one. Eight hours a week to two.
- **A link to one thing you built** that a stranger can open, if you have one. It does not have to be large. It has to be real.
- **Your education, translated carefully.** Secondary school is secondary school. See Chapter A.
- **A bachelor's degree named as a bachelor's degree**, and a postgraduate specialization named as a specialization.
- **Your credential assessment and where it stands**, if you have one in progress:

> *Credential assessment in progress — expected completion March 2027.*

- **Reverse chronological order.** Most recent job first.
- **Two pages maximum.** One if you have under five years of experience.

◆

The test

Read your résumé and ask one question of every line: **does this help them picture what I did?** If it does not, it is taking up space that a number could be using.

◆

A sample

Here is what the two lists look like when they are applied. Read it once for the shape, then a second time for what is missing from it.

MARIANA COSTA

PROJECT MANAGER · CONSTRUCTION AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Burnaby, BC · (604) 555-0142 · mariana.costa@example.com

SUMMARY

Project manager with 12 years of experience delivering commercial and infrastructure projects in São Paulo, now based in British Columbia. Led teams of up to 40 people and budgets of up to CAD 15 million. PMP certified. Fluent in Portuguese and English.

EXPERIENCE

Project Coordinator

2025 – Present

Coastline Builders Ltd. — Burnaby, BC

- Coordinate schedules and subcontractors for **three mixed-use residential projects** worth a combined CAD 48 million.
- Introduced a shared submittal log that cut review turnaround from **ten days to six**.

Senior Project Manager

2014 – 2024

Construtora Horizonte — São Paulo, Brazil

- Delivered **nine commercial and infrastructure projects** on schedule, the largest worth about CAD 15 million.
- Led teams of up to **40 engineers, technicians and subcontractors**.
- Reduced rework costs by **18 per cent** with a weekly quality-inspection routine.

CERTIFICATIONS

Project Management Professional (PMP), 2019 · Basic First Aid (WorkSafeBC-approved), 2025

SKILLS

Scheduling (MS Project, Primavera P6) · cost control · contract administration · site safety · Portuguese (native), English (professional), Spanish (intermediate)

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Civil Engineering, Brazil · credential assessed for Canadian equivalency

What is missing from it

No photograph. No date of birth. No marital status, no children, no identity number. No street address — a city and a province.

Every bullet carries a number, or it carries a change. "Responsible for projects" would have told you nothing; nine projects and a team of forty tell you the scale, and ten days down to six tells you something worked.

And it is one page.

CHAPTER D

WHAT EACH SECTOR IS TESTING

The employer names change. What is being assessed does not change nearly as much.

Nine sectors, the B.C. and national employers you are most likely to meet in each, and what the interview is really about. Match your six stories to the column you are applying into.

◆

Health care

Vancouver Coastal Health · Fraser Health · Providence Health Care · Island Health · Provincial Health Services Authority (including BC Cancer and BC Children's Hospital)

Testing: conduct under emotional load, confidentiality, safety, and whether you report bad news.

Panel format, scored against a written guide built from the posted competencies. Long processes. Your best stories are the ones where somebody was distressed and you behaved well, and where something went wrong and you told someone.

Public sector

Government of Canada · Canada Revenue Agency · Service Canada · BC Public Service · WorkSafeBC · ICBC · BC Housing

Testing: fairness, objectivity, integrity, handling sensitive information, following procedure when it is inconvenient.

The most structured processes in the country, frequently scored numerically against defined competencies. This is the format that rewards preparation most and personality least — which, if you are competing against native speakers, is an advantage. Read the posting as a syllabus.

Utilities, transport and aviation

BC Hydro · FortisBC · TransLink · BC Ferries · Air Canada · WestJet · CN · CPKC · Port of Vancouver

Testing: safety judgment above all. Will you follow the procedure when the shortcut is faster? Will you speak up before an accident rather than after?

Your safety story is not optional here. It is the interview.

Construction and infrastructure

PCL · Ledcor · EllisDon · Kiewit · Graham · Bosa · Aecon

Testing: what you do when a plan fails, coordination under deadline, and whether you take responsibility for your own part.

Do not blame a subcontractor. Explain what you personally did.

Banking and financial services

RBC · TD · CIBC · BMO · Scotiabank · Vancity · Coast Capital Savings

Testing: accuracy, trust, and the tension between what a customer wants and what policy allows.

Every story should show you being careful with something that mattered — money, data, a document, a deadline.

Retail and consumer

Aritzia · Lululemon · Canadian Tire · Costco · London Drugs · Save-On-Foods · Best Buy · Loblaw

Testing: customer experience, and whether your standards survive speed.

Demonstrate service with a story. Do not define it.

Technology

Amazon · Microsoft · Shopify · Telus · SAP · Later · Vancouver's game studios

Testing: how you think when you do not have the information, and what you do when the first solution fails.

Explain the reasoning, not just the outcome. Expect follow-up questions about your process.

The portfolio question is now standard here, and is spreading beyond it. One small deployed project, with an honest account of what it gets wrong, is worth more than any list of tools. See Case 10.

Professional services

Deloitte · KPMG · EY · PwC · MNP · Grant Thornton

Testing: analysis leading to a recommendation, influence without authority, competing priorities.

Structure your answer as: problem, analysis, alternatives considered, recommendation, result. They are listening for the alternatives.

Education and research

UBC · Simon Fraser University · BCIT · Langara · Vancouver Community College · school districts

Testing: collaboration across very different roles and levels of expertise.

Your best story involves people who wanted different things from the same work — and how you adapted your communication rather than winning.

PART SIX

THE WORDS YOU WILL NEED

Everything up to here has been about what to say.

This part is about the words themselves — the specific verbs, sentences and terms that do the work in a Canadian interview. Most of them are lifted directly from the strong answers in Part Three, because that is where you saw them working.

Five chapters. Treat them as a phrasebook, not a chapter to read once.

CHAPTER E

THE VERBS THAT CARRY EVIDENCE

Look again at the strong answers in Part Three and you will notice that the good ones are built on a small number of precise verbs.

This is not decoration. A precise verb *is* the evidence. "I mapped the process" tells the interviewer what you physically did; "I looked at the process" does not. The verb is where a vague answer becomes a specific one.

Here are the verbs that appeared in the strong answers, grouped by what they prove.

Investigating — proves you found out rather than guessed

identified · mapped · reviewed · traced · analyzed · audited · diagnosed · tested · verified · quantified · investigated · compared · measured

> *"I pulled the dispatch records for ninety days and mapped where each late order had lost its time."*

Most candidates say "I looked into it." These verbs say how.

Deciding — proves judgment, not just activity

prioritized · triaged · assessed · weighed · chose · postponed · declined · escalated · redistributed · sequenced · deferred

> *"I triaged the whole board — I went through every patient and sorted them into who needed attention within the hour."*

escalated deserves special mention. Raising something early to the right person is judgment, and many candidates hide it because they think it makes them look unable to cope. It does the opposite.

Building and fixing — proves you changed something

designed · built · implemented · introduced · streamlined · standardized · automated · consolidated · documented · rebuilt · reorganized · simplified

> *"I set up a simple end-of-day check so that anything confirmed after four o'clock got flagged for the morning shift."*

Working through people — proves influence without authority

coordinated · negotiated · persuaded · briefed · trained · delegated · mediated · aligned · consulted · handed over

Notice how few of these require a title. You can coordinate, brief, train and mediate as the most junior person in a team.

Protecting — proves you can be trusted

flagged · reported · isolated · restricted · secured · verified · double-checked · logged · disclosed · stopped

> *"I taped it off, and called the site supervisor that evening."*

stopped is the strongest verb in a safety interview. Stopping work is what employers in construction, utilities and healthcare are hoping to hear.

Owning — proves accountability

disclosed · corrected · acknowledged · took responsibility for · reported early · absorbed · rebuilt

> *"I told my manager the same day rather than waiting for it to surface."*

◆

The test

For each of your six stories, underline every verb in the action section. If you find *helped*, *worked on*, *dealt with*, *handled* or *was involved in*, replace it with something from the lists above.

If you cannot find a precise verb, that usually means you have not yet remembered what you actually did.

CHAPTER F

THE SENTENCES THAT HOLD AN ANSWER TOGETHER

Learn these as fixed phrases. Do not translate them each time — an interview is not the moment to be constructing sentences from parts.

Opening: telling them the shape

- *"There were two parts to this — let me take them in order."*
- *"This is probably my best example of that."*
- *"I'll give you a specific week, if that's useful."*
- *"Some context first, then what I did."*

A panel that knows the shape of your answer can follow it. A panel that does not has to build the structure and absorb the content at the same time, and one of those tasks gets dropped.

Establishing scale

- *"To give you a sense of the size — we were three people covering what was normally five."*
- *"About a quarter of our orders were affected, over roughly three months."*
- *"It was a six-person shop."*

Never assume the interviewer can picture your workplace. They cannot.

Claiming your part

- *"My responsibility was..."*

- *"I was the one who..."*
- *"What I did first was..."*
- *"That decision was mine."*
- *"My part in that was..."*

Say **I**. A panel scoring individual competency cannot award marks to a team. If you find yourself saying *we* four times in a row, stop and say what you personally did.

Explaining a choice

- *"The reason I chose that was..."*
- *"I considered X, but..."*
- *"What made me decide was..."*
- *"I weighed it against..."*

Interviewers probe choices more than actions. Having a reason ready is what separates someone who did the thing from someone who has learned to describe it.

Giving the result

- *"Within about three months..."*
- *"The change was still in use when I left."*
- *"It went from roughly X to roughly Y."*
- *"Nothing was late that had a hard date."*

Limiting honestly — the phrases that buy credibility

- *"I don't have an exact measurement, but..."*
- *"Approximately." · "Roughly." · "In the range of..."*
- *"That's my estimate rather than a figure I measured."*
- *"It didn't fix everything — the fourth field still had to be done by hand."*
- *"I don't want to pretend it was free."*

These cost nothing and protect every other number you give.

Buying time — memorize these

- *"Let me think about that for a moment."*
- *"That's a good question — give me a second to pick the right example."*
- *"Can I come back to that at the end?"*

Two seconds of silence feels enormous to you and is barely noticed by the panel. What they notice is a better answer.

Checking you understood — memorize these too

- *"I want to make sure I answer the right question — when you say X, do you mean...?"*
- *"Could you say a little more about what you mean by that?"*
- *"Could you rephrase that for me?"*

Guessing costs the whole question. Clarifying costs eight seconds and demonstrates something employers actively want.

Closing an answer cleanly

- *"That's the example I'd give."*
- *"Does that answer what you were asking?"*
- *"I'd be happy to go into more detail on any part of that."*

Then stop. Candidates who keep talking into the silence frequently talk over their own best point.

Handling what you don't have

- *"I haven't used that specific system. I've used two others — I learned the second in about a week."*
- *"That's not something I've done. The closest I've come is..."*
- *"I'd want to know whether yours is doing anything unusual."*

Redirecting a question you'd rather not answer

- *"I'm fully available for the shift pattern in the posting, including weekends."*
- *"I'd rather keep the focus on the role, if that's all right."*

CHAPTER G

THE WORDS THAT MAKE YOU INVISIBLE

Some words are not wrong. They simply carry no information, and an answer built from them cannot be scored.

The invisibility verbs

YOU SAY	THE PANEL WRITES DOWN	SAY INSTEAD
"I **helped** with the project"	nothing	"I ran the client communication for it"
"I was **involved in** the change"	nothing	"I mapped the process and proposed the fix"
"I **participated in** the training"	nothing	"I delivered three sessions of it"
"I **worked on** the backlog"	nothing	"I cleared 200 of the 340 open items"
"I **dealt with** customers"	nothing	"I served about fifty customers a day"
"I **was part of** a team that..."	nothing	"My part was the scheduling"
"I **assisted** the manager"	nothing	"I prepared the weekly reports she presented"

Each of these hides you inside a group. That is exactly what a modest, well-mannered person does — and in a scored interview it is indistinguishable from having done nothing.

The shrinking words

Delete these:

just · only · a little bit · kind of · sort of · I think maybe · I'm not really an expert but · it was nothing special · anyone could have done it

> ~~*"I just helped a little bit with the scheduling."*~~ ***"I rebuilt the scheduling."***

Understating true things is not modesty in this context. It is inaccuracy, and the interviewer has no way to know you are being modest rather than marginal.

The filler words

basically · actually · obviously · you know · like · as I said

Record yourself once and count them. Most people have one signature filler and can lose it in a week simply by hearing it.

The claim words that need evidence behind them

These are not banned. They are only worthless *alone*:

hardworking · reliable · proactive · detail-oriented · team player · fast learner · passionate · dynamic · results-driven

Every one of these is a claim anyone can make. Use them only as a label on a story you are about to tell, never as the story itself.

> ~~*"I'm a fast learner."*~~ ***"I had a weekend to learn the scheduling software. By Monday it was running."***

CHAPTER H

THE VOCABULARY OF A CANADIAN WORKPLACE

Words you will hear in interviews and on the job, which have no obvious equivalent in a Brazilian workplace or which mean something narrower than you would expect.

Work arrangements

shift — a defined block of working hours. *Rotating shift*, *graveyard shift* (overnight), *swing shift* (evening). **casual** — employed but with no guaranteed hours. Very common in health care. Not the same as part-time. **on call** — available to be called in. Whether the waiting time is paid, and at what rate, depends on the employer and the contract. **stat** (statutory holiday) — a public holiday. *Stat pay* is the premium for working it. **OT** — overtime. **probation** — the first three to six months, during which dismissal is easier. Normal, not a warning sign. **seniority** — in unionized workplaces, length of service determines shift choice, layoff order and sometimes promotion. This is often surprising to newcomers. **union · non-union · grievance · steward** — worth understanding before interviewing in construction, transit, health care or the public sector.

How work moves

handover (or *handoff*) — passing responsibility at the end of a shift. In health care this is a formal, high-stakes event. **escalate** — raise to a more senior person. Positive, not a failure. **flag** — draw attention to something before it becomes a problem. **backlog** — accumulated unfinished work.

turnaround time — how long something takes end to end. **scope** — what a project does and does not include. *Scope creep* is uncontrolled expansion. **SOP** — standard operating procedure. **toolbox talk** — a short safety briefing at the start of a shift, usually in construction and trades. **PPE** — personal protective equipment. **due diligence** — the checking you are expected to do before acting.

People

direct manager · direct report · dotted line — who you report to, who reports to you, and an informal reporting relationship. **stakeholder** — anyone affected by or interested in the work. Used constantly in the public sector. **cross-functional** — involving several departments. **client-facing** — dealing directly with customers or clients.

Hiring

posting (or *req*, short for requisition) — the advertised job. **screening** — the first cut, often before a human reads your résumé. **shortlist** — the candidates invited to interview. **panel** — two or more interviewers scoring independently. **competency** — a defined skill the interview is scoring you against. Usually listed in the posting. **reference check** — the call to your former manager. **offer conditional on** — the job is yours provided something (a check, a licence, a clearance) comes through.

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Decoding the posting

Job postings use a small set of coded phrases. Each one is asking for a specific kind of evidence. Match your stories to them.

THE POSTING SAYS	IT IS ASKING	YOUR STORY SHOULD SHOW
"attention to detail"	Can we trust your accuracy?	A time accuracy mattered and how you checked
"fast-paced environment"	Do your standards survive volume?	Scale, plus what you did *not* let slip
"self-starter"	Do we have to tell you?	Something you noticed and took on unasked
"works well under pressure"	What happens when it is bad?	The size of the pressure, then your method
"team player"	Are you difficult?	A disagreement handled without damage
"comfortable with ambiguity"	Can you act without full information?	A decision made on partial facts, and why
"stakeholder management"	Can you handle competing interests?	Two groups wanting different things
"continuous improvement"	Do you leave things better?	A process you changed, with the cost before
"customer-focused"	Will you protect the relationship?	A specific customer, not a philosophy
"safety-conscious"	Will you speak up when it costs?	A time you did the harder correct thing
"adaptable"	What happens when the plan changes?	A plan that failed and what you did next
"takes ownership"	Will you tell us when it goes wrong?	Your own mistake, disclosed early

CHAPTER I

THE PHONE SCREEN

There is one interview format made entirely of words.

No face, no room, no handshake, no gesture, no way to see whether the person is writing or has stopped listening. Everything in Part Two is unavailable to you. Everything in this part is all you have.

It is also, for a second-language speaker, the most winnable interview you will ever have — and almost nobody prepares for it, because it does not feel like an interview.

What it actually is

Fifteen to twenty-five minutes. Usually a recruiter or an HR coordinator, not the person you would work for. Frequently unscheduled, or scheduled with a day's notice.

It is a **screen**, not a selection. Nobody is being hired on this call. People are being removed from it, usually for one of five reasons:

1. They are not authorized to work here, or the permit expires too soon.
2. Their salary expectation is far outside the range.
3. They cannot start when the job starts.
4. The commute or shift pattern will not work.
5. They could not hold a clear conversation.

Four of those five are facts you already know. Decide them before the phone rings and the call becomes almost impossible to fail.

The advantage nobody uses

You can read.

This is the only interview format in which you may have every note you own in front of you, and no one will ever know. Candidates routinely take this call while walking to the bus, and then perform from memory in a language they are still building.

Put on your desk, before the call:

- The posting, printed
- Your six four-word cards
- Your salary floor, written down
- The sentence from Case 3 that explains your last employer
- Three questions to ask
- The name of the person calling, and the job title

You will use perhaps a third of it. The value is that nothing has to be retrieved under pressure.

The disadvantage nobody mentions

A phone line is compressed, narrow-band audio. It strips out exactly the high frequencies that distinguish consonants — and it removes lip movement, which listeners use more than they realize.

Everything in Chapter B costs you more on a phone than in a room. The extra vowel at the end of words, the *-ed* endings, *live* and *leave* — all harder to resolve when the listener has only a degraded audio signal and no face to read.

So: **slow down further than feels necessary.** More than in person. This is the single adjustment that matters.

The practical rules

Take it somewhere quiet, on headphones. Not on speaker. Not in a car, a café, on transit, or while walking. If they call unexpectedly and you are somewhere unsuitable, say so and offer a time:

> *"I'm out at the moment and the line isn't good — could I call you back in an hour? I'd rather give you my full attention."*

Nobody has ever been rejected for this. Several people have been rejected for taking the call in a supermarket.

Get the callback number at the start. Lines drop. If you have the number, a dropped call is an inconvenience; if you do not, it is the end of the process.

Say when you cannot hear. Early, once, without embarrassment:

> *"I'm losing you slightly — could you say that again?"*

Stand up. Your voice carries better and your energy travels down a line that is otherwise flattening you.

Talking into silence

The hardest part of a phone screen is that you cannot see whether your answer landed. In a room you would read a face and stop. On a phone you keep going, and keep going, and the answer dissolves.

Two techniques.

Signpost harder than you would in person. Everything in Chapter F matters more here, because it is the only structure the listener gets:

> *"There were two parts to this — let me take them in order."*

Check in, out loud, at the end of a long answer:

> *"Is that the level of detail you wanted, or would it help if I went further into the result?"*

This is not weakness. It is the only substitute available for reading the room, and recruiters find it easy to work with.

The money question

The phone screen is where salary comes up, more often than at any later stage, and usually early.

This is where a low number does the most damage, because it is recorded and travels with your file into every later conversation. Have your range and your floor written in front of you, and use the sentence from Case 11:

> *"Based on what I've seen for similar roles in the Lower Mainland, I'd be looking at somewhere between X and Y, depending on the full scope. Does that fit your range?"*

Closing

Ask two things before you hang up:

> *"What does the next stage look like?" "When are you hoping to make a decision?"*

You now know the format of the next interview and when to follow up. Write both down immediately, along with the recruiter's name, because in four weeks you will not remember which company said what.

CLOSING

Fifty-two cases, and not one of them had a perfect answer.

Marcela forgot her words. Bruno gave a forgettable answer and had to go home and find the numbers. Rafael named a salary that was too low. Diego wore the wrong clothes and was rejected after a second interview. Ana was ashamed of a warehouse job that turned out to be the best evidence she had. Rodrigo had six years of work nobody was allowed to see, so he built something they could.

What they had in common was not talent, or fluency, or luck.

They found out what they had.

They practised saying it out loud.

And when somebody asked them a question, they did not describe their qualities.

They gave the evidence and let the interviewer decide.

APPENDIX

The Six Cards

Reduce each of your six stories to one card. Four words on the front. That is all you need in the room.

> **Story 1**
>
> **Situation:** _____
>
> **Task:** _____
>
> **Action:** _____
>
> **Result:** _____

> **Story 2**
>
> **Situation:** _____
>
> **Task:** _____
>
> **Action:** _____
>
> **Result:** _____

> **Story 3**
>
> **Situation:** _____
>
> **Task:** _____
>
> **Action:** _____
>
> **Result:** _____

Story 4

Situation: _____

Task: _____

Action: _____

Result: _____

Story 5

Situation: _____

Task: _____

Action: _____

Result: _____

Story 6

Situation: _____

Task: _____

Action: _____

Result: _____

What Each Card Can Answer

Beside each story, list every question it could answer. If a story answers fewer than three, look at it again before you look for another one.

The Empty Lines

Print the posting. One line per requirement. Write your story beside each. The requirements with nothing beside them are your preparation.

Before You Walk In

- Three sentences of small talk
- Four questions to ask them
- Your salary floor, written down
- Two arrival times, twenty minutes apart
- Where your hands will rest

Your Personal False Friends

Most people have between four and nine, and they are the same ones every time. Read your six stories aloud, watching only for the words in Chapter A, and write yours here. Ignore the rest of the list.

WHAT I SAY	WHAT THEY HEAR	WHAT I WILL SAY INSTEAD

The Résumé Strip

Take off:

- [ ] Photograph
- [ ] Date of birth / age
- [ ] Marital status, children, dependants
- [ ] Gender
- [ ] CPF, RG or passport number
- [ ] Nationality
- [ ] Full street address (city and province is enough)

- [ ] Religion, health status, signature
- [ ] The long "Objective" paragraph
- [ ] Duties with no results attached
- [ ] References and their contact details

Put on:

- [ ] Canadian-format phone number
- [ ] Professional email address
- [ ] Two- or three-line summary
- [ ] A descriptor line under every employer nobody here has heard of
- [ ] Numbers in your achievements
- [ ] Education translated correctly (secondary school is secondary school)
- [ ] Credential assessment status and expected date
- [ ] Two pages maximum

The One-Way Video Checklist

Before you press record:

- [ ] Read the invitation — how many questions, how long to think, how long to answer, how many takes
- [ ] Camera at eye level, light in front of you, window behind the screen
- [ ] Four-word cards on the wall directly behind the laptop
- [ ] One practice answer recorded in the actual software
- [ ] Every answer finishing inside the limit, not filling it

The Overseas Reference

Send them, in Portuguese, at least a week ahead:

- [ ] The job title and a short description of the role
- [ ] The three things you hope they will speak to
- [ ] The likely time of the call, in their time zone
- [ ] That answering in writing is an acceptable option

Then tell the employer before they ask.

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